PHILADELPHIA, UNITED STATES

Philadelphia Museum of Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works that make visibility itself part of the subject.



Tanner's angel appears as a shaft of light, with no winged body to identify. Duchamp's *With Hidden Noise* puts something inside a ball of twine, where looking cannot reach it. Degas places two people in a furnished room but declines to provide the event that would fully explain their separation.

These are different kinds of withholding, not clues to a single secret. A work can leave an object invisible, a story unresolved or a material boundary uncertain. This Philadelphia selection follows the choices that let an image remain specific without explaining everything. It also includes pictures of public demonstration and performance, where the presence of an audience determines what is made visible in the first place.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/philadelphia-museum-art

The selection · 20

1. The Annunciation
   Henry Ossawa Tanner · 1898
2. The Gross Clinic
   Thomas Eakins · 1875
3. The Bride Stripped Bare by Her Bachelors, Even
   Marcel Duchamp · 1915-1923
4. The Burning of the Houses of Parliament
   J. M. W. Turner · 1834–1835
5. Carnival Evening
   Henri Rousseau · 1885-1886
6. Dog Barking at the Moon
   Joan Miró · 1926
7. At the Moulin Rouge: The Dance
   Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec · 1890
8. Disks of Newton: Study for Fugue in Two Colours
   František Kupka · c. 1911
9. Male and Female
   Jackson Pollock · 1942
10. Cosimo I de' Medici as Orpheus
    Bronzino · c. 1538
11. Blessing Christ and Praying Virgin
    Robert Campin · 1424
12. With Hidden Noise
    Marcel Duchamp · 1916
13. Interior
    Edgar Degas · 1868-1869
14. Pietà
    El Greco · 1575
15. Violin and Newspaper
    Georges Braque · c. 1912
16. William Rush Carving His Allegorical Figure of the Schuylkill River
    Thomas Eakins · 1877
17. Pope Pius VII with Cardinal Caprara
    Jacques-Louis David · 1805
18. The Poet, or Half Past Three
    Marc Chagall · 1911-1912
19. Madonna with the Writing Child
    Pinturicchio · 1498
20. The Six Elements
    René Magritte · 1928

01 / 20

The Annunciation

Henry Ossawa Tanner

1898 · Oil · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Henry Ossawa Tanner. The Annunciation. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henry-ossawa-tanner/the-annunciation-1898 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Gabriel's presence changes the room as light, rather than entering it as a recognisable winged figure. Tanner seats Mary on the bed in rumpled clothing, without the halo that often identifies her. The rough walls and ordinary furnishings make the supernatural encounter occur within a particular inhabited space. Her attention supplies the human response to something that has no human outline.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Gross Clinic

Thomas Eakins

1875 · Philadelphia Museum of Art and Pennsylvania Academy of the Fine Arts (joint ownership)



Thomas Eakins. The Gross Clinic. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The standing surgeon addresses a theatre of watchers while the assistants continue their physical work. Eakins makes medical knowledge public through a patient's vulnerable body. Blood and concentrated attention belong to the same demonstration. The picture is jointly owned by the Philadelphia Museum of Art and the Pennsylvania Academy of the Fine Arts; its inclusion here is not a promise of display at one location.

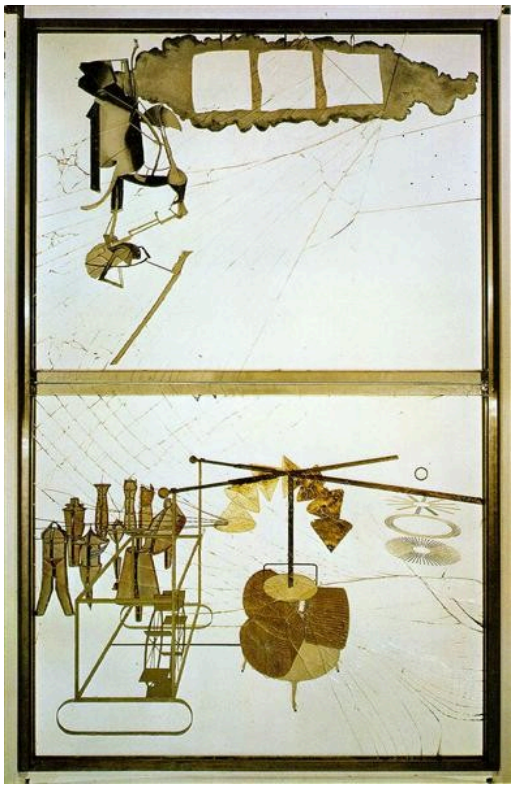
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Bride Stripped Bare by Her Bachelors, Even

Marcel Duchamp

1915-1923 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Marcel Duchamp. The Bride Stripped Bare by her Bachelors. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The mechanical forms occupy transparent glass, so the room behind cannot be wholly excluded from the image. Duchamp gives the construction a title suggesting people and an event, then refuses the clarity of an ordinary figure scene. Cracks remain part of the encountered surface. Looking has to move between the apparatus, its support and whatever the transparency admits from beyond.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Burning of the Houses of Parliament

J. M. W. Turner

1834–1835 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



J. M. W. Turner. The Burning of the Houses of Parliament. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Fire spreads through Turner's picture as light on the river, smoke in the sky and a changing view of architecture. Crowds and boats establish the event as something watched collectively. The museum dates this painting to 1834–1835; the fire itself occurred on 16 October 1834. Keeping those dates distinct separates the catastrophe from the subsequent work of representing it.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Carnival Evening

Henri Rousseau

1885-1886 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Henri Rousseau. Carnival Evening. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The costumes refer to festivities that the surrounding landscape does little to confirm. Rousseau leaves the two pale figures beneath bare trees and a moon, small against the darkness. The celebration is present as dress rather than crowd or noise. That disparity gives the scene its uncertainty: the title supplies an occasion, but the visible setting does not settle what is happening.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Dog Barking at the Moon

Joan Miró

1926 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Joan Miró. Dog Barking at the Moon. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The dog and crescent occupy widely separated positions in the dark field. Miró's long ladder seems to offer a connection, though its scale makes that possibility peculiar. With so few forms, each interval becomes consequential. The picture can suggest an exchange across an unmanageable distance without turning the ladder into a practical route or the moon into an ordinary destination.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1952-61-82

07 / 20

At the Moulin Rouge: The Dance

Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec

1890 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec. At the Moulin Rouge, The Dance. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The dancers need the open patch of floor created by the people around them. Toulouse-Lautrec records several degrees of involvement: performing, watching, talking and standing at the edge. The room's social arrangement is therefore part of the dance, not its background alone. Bright clothing helps separate figures whose attention does not necessarily converge on the same action.

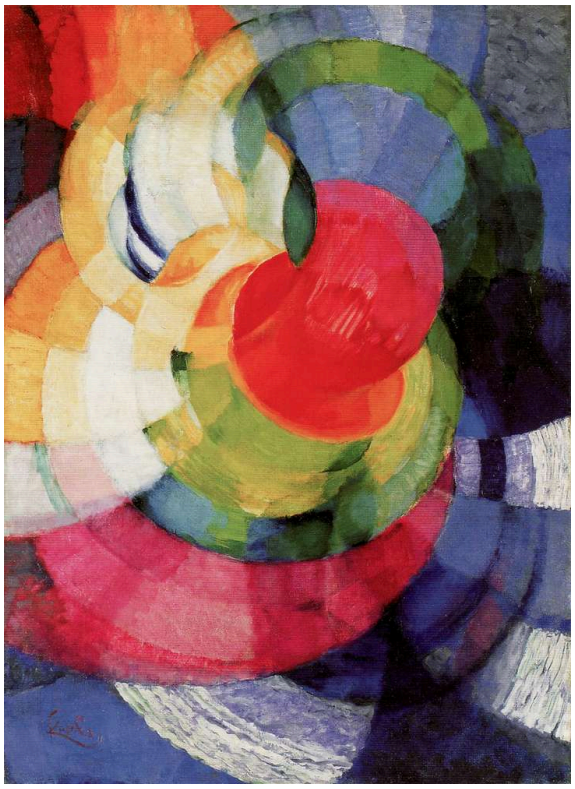
Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Disks of Newton: Study for Fugue in Two Colours

František Kupka

c. 1911 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



František Kupka. Disks of Newton, Study for Fugue in Two Colors. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/frantisek-kupka/disks-of-newton-study-for-fugue-in-two-colors · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Arcs pass over and behind one another without attaching themselves to a depicted machine or body. Kupka makes the sequence of colours and curved bands carry movement. The musical reference in the title offers a comparison rather than a tune to decode. Attention follows relations and recurrence across the surface, not the progress of an identifiable object through a landscape.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Male and Female

Jackson Pollock

1942 · Oil on canvas · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Male and Female. WikiArt; Jackson Pollock. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Jackson Pollock

Two upright forms remain partly recognisable as figures among numbers, loops and coloured patches. Pollock does not fully separate them from the surrounding activity. The painting allows bodies and independent marks to compete on the same terms. Rather than treating it only as a step towards later work, notice the particular tension created by keeping both kinds of image present here.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Cosimo I de' Medici as Orpheus

Bronzino

c. 1538 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Bronzino. Portrait of Cosimo I de' Medici as Orpheus. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/agnolo-bronzino/portrait-of-cosimo-i-de-medici-as-orpheus · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The stringed instrument and mythological role replace ordinary court dress as the means of presenting Cosimo. Bronzino combines an identifiable face with an idealised nude body. The portrait does not simply show what the ruler looked like. It shows how a likeness can be joined to a story in order to construct an identity beyond the sitter's everyday appearance.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Blessing Christ and Praying Virgin

Robert Campin

1424 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Robert Campin. Blessing Christ and Praying Virgin. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

One pair of hands is joined in prayer; another hand is raised in blessing. The close presentation against gold brings those actions into direct relation, leaving little room for an anecdotal setting. Small differences of gaze and gesture do the explanatory work. The images ask for sustained attention to two sacred presences rather than an account of a single unfolding event.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

With Hidden Noise

Marcel Duchamp

1916 · Ready-made · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Marcel Duchamp. With Hidden Noise. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/marcel-duchamp/with-hidden-noise-1916 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Metal plates and long screws hold the twine in a compact assembly. The title points towards something the eye cannot inventory: an object concealed within it, and the sound associated with that concealment. Duchamp sets a limit on visual inspection. Knowing the outer construction more precisely does not necessarily reveal what is inside, so description cannot exhaust the work.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Interior

Edgar Degas

1868-1869 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Edgar Degas. Interior (The Rape). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The man stands near the doorway while the woman bends elsewhere in the dim room. Furniture and scattered things increase the separation between their unequal poses. Degas supplies enough specificity to suggest a story, but not enough to establish one securely. The room's tension can be discussed without turning an evocative arrangement into proof of a particular event.

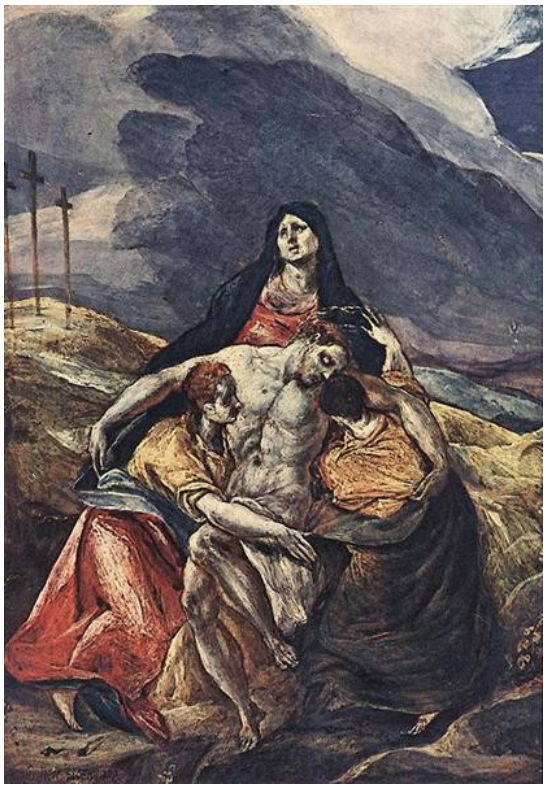
Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Pietà

El Greco

1575 · Tempera on panel · Philadelphia Museum of Art



El Greco; WikiArt; Public domain (WikiArt label). Source frame preserved; proportionally resized and JPEG compressed. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Mary's support of Christ's pale body gives the angular group its physical necessity. El Greco elongates limbs and sharpens folds so that grief does not settle into a smoothly balanced display. The broken landscape continues the unsettled arrangement beyond the figures. The point of contact between a living body and a dead one remains the scene's most direct explanation.

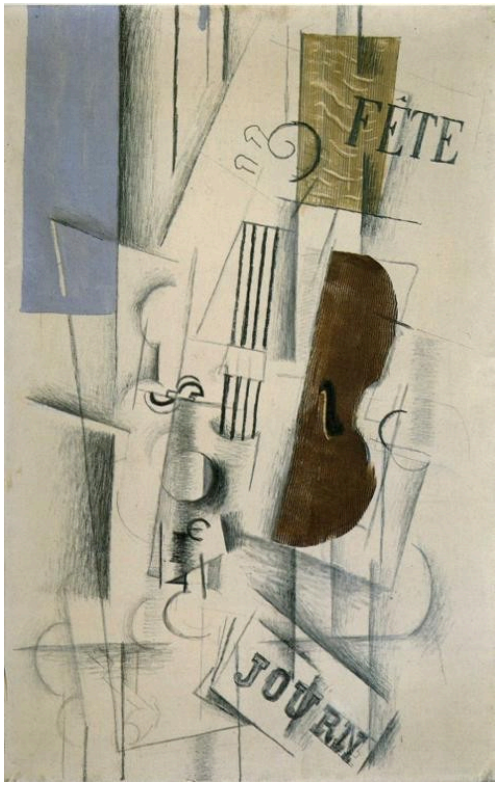
Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Violin and Newspaper

Georges Braque

c. 1912 · Charcoal and oil on canvas · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Georges Braque. Violin and Newspaper (Musical Forms). WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georges-braque/violin-and-newspaper-musical-forms · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

A few curves can suggest a violin even when its complete outline is withheld. Braque places that incomplete recognition beside lettering, making reading and looking proceed together. Overlapping planes do not agree on a single viewpoint. The instrument has to be assembled from clues, while the newspaper's signs demonstrate another familiar way of making meaning from separated marks.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

William Rush Carving His Allegorical Figure of the Schuylkill River

Thomas Eakins

1877 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Thomas Eakins. William Rush Carving His Allegorical Figure of the Schuykill River. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The model, sculptor and developing figure occupy different stages in the making of a public image. Eakins keeps clothes, tools and the seated companion within the studio, refusing to show the allegory as though it arrived already complete. A river acquires a human form through labour and posing. The ordinary conditions of that transformation remain visible beside its idealised result.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Pope Pius VII with Cardinal Caprara

Jacques-Louis David

1805 · Oil on panel · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Pope Pius VII with the Cardinal Caprara. WikiArt; Jacques-Louis David. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The overlapping figures are separated by their positions, contrasting garments and different turns of the face. David gives institutional hierarchy a compact visual arrangement. Pale robes and red accents emerge from the dark setting without eliminating the individuality of either sitter. Authority is represented through a relationship between people, not through costume considered in isolation.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

The Poet, or Half Past Three

Marc Chagall

1911-1912 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Marc Chagall. The Poet, or Half Past Three. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The green head's rotation disrupts a room whose furniture remains recognisable. Chagall carries bright geometric divisions through both setting and body, allowing them to share the same instability. The unusual orientation can suggest dislocation without providing a literal diagnosis or a single account of thought. The room needs to remain partly ordinary for the bodily departure from it to register.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Madonna with the Writing Child

Pinturicchio

1498 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



Pinturicchio. Madonna with Writing Child. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The book gives the child's hands an activity within Mary's embrace. Pinturicchio holds bodily closeness and the act of writing together, while the landscape opens beyond them. The gesture complicates an otherwise familiar mother-and-child arrangement: the infant is presented as attending to knowledge as well as receiving care. The joined hands help the two roles remain visually connected.

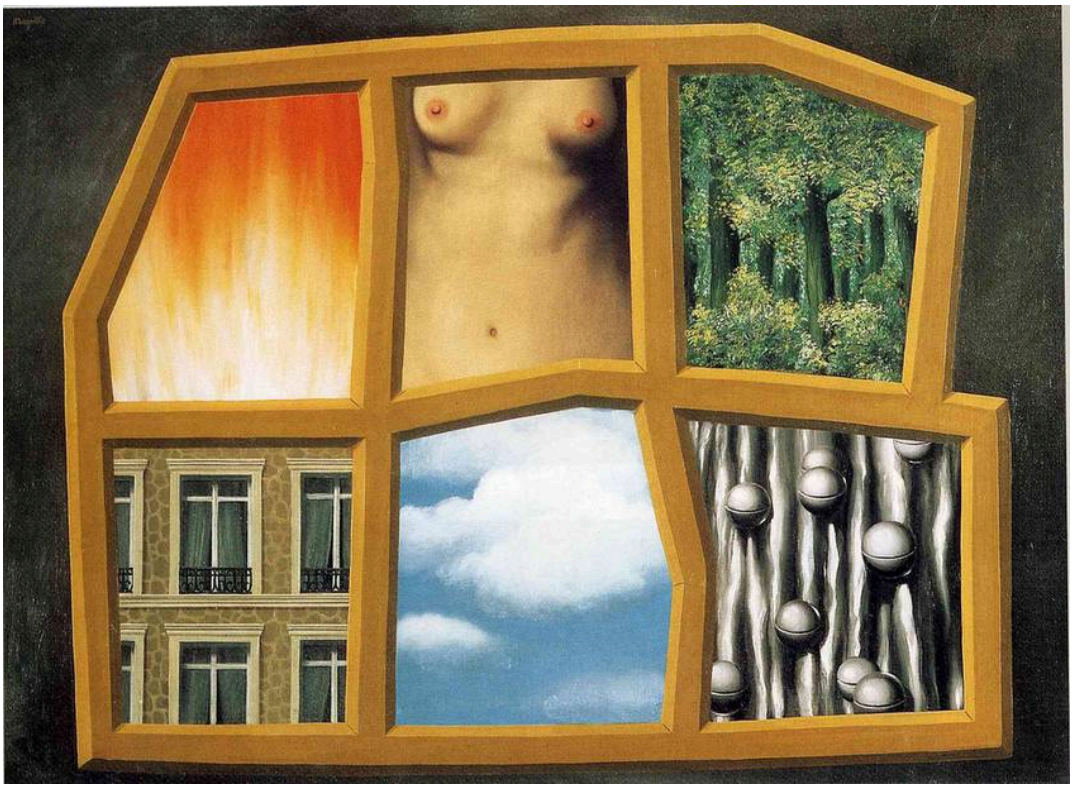
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

The Six Elements

René Magritte

1928 · Philadelphia Museum of Art



René Magritte. The six elements. WikiArt source label: Rene Magritte Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/rene-magritte/the-six-elements-1928 · Rene Magritte Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

The separate compartments promise an orderly classification, but the things placed inside do not follow a consistent rule. Fire, torso, landscape and other forms differ in scale and kind. Magritte uses the frame's regularity to make that mismatch more apparent. Dividing a set neatly does not establish what its members share, however authoritative the arrangement may look.

Object source · Open artwork

Leave room for what remains unresolved

Distinguish a hidden physical object from an uncertain story. Duchamp's construction and Degas's room withhold information in different ways, and each rewards a different question. For a visit, verify current display separately; *The Gross Clinic* has joint institutional ownership, and the complete selection should not be treated as a fixed route through one building.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s account of drawing and tonal arrangement provides a practical starting point for Tanner, Eakins and Degas. The abstract and assembled works later in the selection let you test where that account becomes less applicable.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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